

flesh¹—this is the deceiver, even the Antichrist!” “Anyone who turns aside and does not continue in the teaching of Christ does not have God; but whoever continues in Christ’s teaching does have both the Father and the Son. If anyone comes to you and does not bring this teaching, do not receive him into your house; do not even tell him, “I wish you well”, because whoever tells him, “I wish you well”, participates in his malignant works.”² Some might feel that John’s language is a little strong, but he was definitely warning them. Going back to verse 7, The Text has “coming”, not ‘having come’, so evidently John is referring to Christ’s second coming, which will certainly be “in flesh”. Recall the word of the angels in Acts 1:11.

Peter’s statement concerning the “twisting” that Paul’s words were receiving (2 Peter 3:16) suggests that there was awareness and concern as to the text and the way it was being handled. I recognize that the Apostles were focusing on the interpretation rather than the copying of the text, and yet, since any alteration of the text may result in a different interpretation we may reasonably infer that their concern for the truth would include the faithful transmission of the text.

Indeed, we could scarcely ask for a clearer expression of this concern than that given in Revelation 22:18-19. “I myself testify to everyone who hears the words of the prophecy of this book: If any one adds to them, may God add to him the seven plagues written in this book! And if anyone takes away from the words³ of the book of this prophecy, may God remove his share from the tree of life and out of the Holy City, that stand written in this book!” Since it is the glorified Christ who is speaking, would not any true follower of His pay careful attention?

¹ Recall the word of the angels in Acts 1:11, “This very Jesus who is being taken up from you into the sky, He will come again in the precise manner that you observed Him going into the sky.” The angels are emphatic; the return is going to be just like the departure. I take it that the Lord will return with the same glorified human body, visibly, come out of a cloud, and His feet will touch down at the same spot where they left (see Matthew 24:30, “coming on the clouds”, and Zechariah 14:4, “His feet will stand on the Mount of Olives”).

² People who do not believe and teach what Christ taught are on the other side. To be malignant is to be aggressively evil. Obviously, we should avoid anything that might be interpreted as identification with such people.

³ “Words”, plural, includes the individual words that make up the whole. Those textual critics who have wantonly removed words from the Text, on the basis of satanically inspired presuppositions, are out. Those who interpret the Text in such a way as to avoid its plain meaning, likewise. Jehovah the Son affirms that the wordsare “true and **faithful**”, and He expects us to interpret them that way.